



RAND

AI Facilitation Group

SESSION 1 · SEPTEMBER 17 AND 18, 2026

What do you want out of this?

A first conversation: how you use these tools now, what you want from the next ten weeks, and how I can help.

WHY THIS GROUP

Everyone here already uses these tools. The question is how well.

Six sessions between now and December, each one built around something you are actually working on: a thesis chapter, a RAND task, a lit review, the qual readings. The aim is better judgment about when to trust the output, and a shared record of what worked and what didn't.

QUICK ROUND · A MINUTE EACH

Who's here

What you're working on this term

Thesis, RAND project, quals, all of the above.

The last thing you used AI for

Work or not. Honest answers welcome.

Which tools you actually reach for

And whether that's the RAND-approved one.

INTO THE CHAT, THEN WE'LL TALK THROUGH THEM

Your time here

- 1 What are you working on this year that these sessions could actually help with?
 - 2 What do you want to be able to do by December that you can't do now?
 - 3 What's a question about AI at RAND you've wanted to ask? Policy, attribution, what's allowed, who to ask.
 - 4 What would make a session worth your time, and what would make you skip one?
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TELL ME IN CHAT WHICH TWO YOU'D ACTUALLY USE

What would help most?

Live demos

I show a technique on a real document, you watch it fail and recover.

Hands-on breakouts

Most of the hour on your own project, in pairs, with me dropping in.

Bring-your-problem clinics

You bring the stuck task, the room works it live.

Office hours

A standing half hour between sessions for one-on-one questions.

The shared Playbook

Async: what worked, what broke, what the model lied about. Yours by December.

Quals prep

A study-partner setup that quizzes you from your own readings without inventing anything.

EVERY SESSION, SAME SHAPE

Ninety minutes, four blocks

10 Cold open One person demos real work since last time	50 Core One technique, hands-on, on your own project. Breakouts for pair work.	15 Debrief What worked, what broke, where it lied. Into the Playbook.	2 Homework Apply it to something real
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The cold open gets assigned at the end of each session, so someone always arrives with real work to show. Every session also ships a one-page takeaway guide you can keep.

THE TERM

Six sessions, then one you pick

Dates	#	Topic	What you leave with
Sep 17 & 18	1	Prompting as spec-writing, and attribution	Prompt frame; the policy
Oct 1 & 2	2	Documents, context rot, and how models fail	File-format guide; failure bins
Oct 15 & 16	3	Code over arithmetic	A script you can read
Oct 29 & 30	4	Agents, subagents, and cost	A tiering guide
Nov 12 & 13	5	Skill docs, with quals in view	Study partner for your readings
Nov 26 & 27		No session: quals and Thanksgiving	
Dec 10 & 11	6	Build something, and the critic in the room	One made thing, critiqued
Jan 7 & 8	7	Whatever the group picks in December	

Prompting as spec-writing

10 The policy, read aloud	10 Excavate your last three prompts	10 The five parts of a spec	15 Rewrite one and run both	10 Pairs: which output is better, and why
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You are briefing a very fast, very literal colleague who has never met you. No chat history to excavate? There are three bad prompts in the takeaway guide you can use instead.

A prompt is a spec with five parts

Part	Ask yourself	Example fragment
Context	Who is this for? What project?	I'm drafting a RAND research brief for a congressional staffer audience.
Task	One verb, one object	Summarize the methodological limitations of this study.
Constraints	Length, sources, tone, exclusions	Under 300 words. Only limitations the authors acknowledge. No recommendations.
Examples	What does good look like?	Here is a paragraph in the house style: [paste].
Output shape	Table? Memo? Bullets?	Three-column table: limitation, page cite, severity.

Not every prompt needs all five. Every prompt should have consciously skipped the ones it skips.

BEFORE OCTOBER 1

Homework, and one volunteer

Rewrite one real prompt a day

Bring the one where the rewrite made the **smallest** difference. That is the interesting case.

Bring one long PDF

Session 2 is documents: something with tables, footnotes, or scanned pages. A GAO report is on hand if you have nothing.

Who does the October 1 cold open?

Ten minutes, real work, since today. The person is named before we leave.

Takeaway guide for today goes out after the session. It has the five parts, the policy pointers, and the reading list.

ONE MORE FOR THE CHAT

What's one thing you'd like to
have figured out by
December?